



Stimming and repetitive behaviours

You may notice that your child uses repetitive behaviours sometimes. 'Stimming' is a stimulatory behaviour that helps neurodivergent children to regulate their emotions, cope with sensory overload, help them concentrate, express excitement or self-soothe. It is helpful for their wellbeing.

Examples of stimming



Hand-flapping



Rocking



Pacing



Spinning



Twirling hair



Fiddling with objects



Rubbing fabrics



Scratching surfaces



Humming



Whistling



Screaming



Clicking



Repetitive blinking



Staring



Chewing



Biting nails

Parenting a child who stims

Remember that stimming helps your child, so wherever possible allow the stimming and encourage them to find ways to self-soothe/ concentrate. You could do this by providing the following:

- Noise cancelling headphones
- Fidget toys
- A quiet space in your home
- Opportunities to get exercise every day
- Ways to relax, e.g. calming activities or mindful breathing techniques.

If your child's stimming is disruptive or harmful to them, try the following tips:

- Re-direct harmful behaviours such as skin-scratching or head-banging to safe options such as rocking, or using weighted blankets, stress balls, physical activities/ exercise, deep breathing or spending time in a calm space.
- If your child uses screaming or squealing to stim, consider why they are doing it. It could be because they are sensory seeking - i.e. it is fun for them. However they may be distressed or struggling to communicate with you. If they are experiencing anxiety or sensory overwhelm, provide them with noise-cancelling headphones or take them to a quieter space. You could also suggest that instead of loud noises, they could try humming a tune, or singing a song quietly.

For more
information
access our family
support library:



For support to
help you feel
calmer while
parenting:

